Soviet government was making efforts to bring about a pan-Islamic bloc ‘consisting of Russia, Turkey, Persia, Afghanistan and possibly other Moslem States, the object being to enable Russia to exercise an influence over Moslem Nationalist movements’.[56]

Nevertheless, the agreement between Turkey and Soviet Russia had been a marriage of convenience, and once Kemal had improved his relations with the Allies (see below), then he would not be quite so keen to be in close collaboration with Moscow. That it was unlikely, however, that Turkey, Persia and Afghanistan would acquiesce in Russian interference in Muslim affairs was not as important to the Home government as the fact that the Soviet government was trying to bring about such an alliance. When combined with the increase in Bolshevik-sponsored agitation in India in 1922, and a variety of smaller irritations, these intrigues by the Soviet government took on greater meaning.[57] To London, it was becoming more and more apparent that Russia was not taking the terms of the trade agreement seriously. By May 1923, Curzon had reached the end of his patience, and gained Cabinet approval of a draft despatch to the Soviet government, detailing the various ways in which the trade agreement had been violated by the latter.[58] The ‘Curzon Note’, as it became known, included, among other things, complaint of Soviet subversive activities in Persia, Afghanistan and India. The note concluded with a demand that the acts of propaganda carried out in these countries be ‘repudiated and apologised for’, and that the officials responsible for them be disowned and recalled. Unless this and the other terms of the agreement were complied with within ten days of receipt of the communication, the trade treaty was to be terminated.[59] One historian has described the note as an example of ‘Curzon’s diplomatic style at its imperious best’.[60]

The Curzon note of 1923, however, was not dissimilar to that which had been sent to Moscow in 1921, the key difference being that the foreign secretary had learnt his lesson from that debacle and this time made quite certain that the 1923 complaint was based on irrefutable evidence, largely in the form of decrypted telegrams (portions of which Curzon could not resist taunting the Soviet regime with).[61] This time around too, although the Soviet government made some attempts at denying the charges laid by Curzon, it was ultimately conciliatory.[62] As the foreign secretary explained